

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1997-03-30

To all National Spiritual Assemblies in Africa

1 dear bahá'í friends,

ever since the launching of the four year plan, the universal house

2 of justice has noted, with deep satisfaction, the manner in which bahá'í

3 institutions and communities of the African continent have welcomed the spirit and
letter of the broad lines of activity set forth in the plan, and have

4 particularly taken to heart its riḥván message for 153 b.e. to the followers

5 of bahá'u'lláh in Africa. As a supplement to that message, the universal

6 house of justice wishes to convey the following comments to your National

7 Spiritual Assemblies, and through you, to the body of believers in that

8 continent.

The development of the teaching work in Africa has always been char-

9 acterized by the receptiveness with which the truths of the revelation of

10 bahá'u'lláh have been accepted and valued by the peoples of that vast con-

11 tinent, by the joy stemming from the pure hearts of the African believers as reflected
in their radiant faces, and by their growing maturity in appreciat-ing the importance of
adherence to bahá'í laws and ordinances.

one of these ordinances is the clear prohibition in the writings of

12 bahá'u'lláh of the consumption of alcoholic drinks. This has been explicitly

13 revealed in his most holy book, the kitáb-i-Aqdas. he states, "i t is inad-

missible that man, who hath been endowed with reason, should consume

14 that which stealeth it away. Nay, rather it behooveth him to comport himself

15 in a manner worthy of the human station, and not in accordance with the misdeeds of
every heedless and wavering soul."

16 247-1 in other Tablets, we read

17 from his glorious pen, "beware lest ye exchange the wine of god for your

18 own wine, for it will stupefy your minds, and turn your faces away from the
countenance of god, the All-glorious, the peerless, the inaccessible.

19 Approach it not, for it hath been forbidden unto you by the behest of god,

the exalted, the Almighty.”

20 247-2

21 247-1. kA, ¶119.

22 247-2. kA, Notes, no. 144.247 .1

247 .2

247 .3

248 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

249 566’Abdu’l-bahá, adding his voice to that of the blessed beauty, has written,

250 “The drinking of wine is, according to the text of the most holy book,

251 forbidden; for it is the cause of chronic diseases, weakeneth the nerves, and

252 consumeth the mind.”247-3 he has also written, “r egarding the use of liquor:

253 according to the text of the book of Aqdas, both light and strong drinks are

254 prohibited.”247-4 he further states, “i ntellect and the faculty of comprehen-

255 sion are god’s gifts whereby man is distinguished from other animals. will

256 a wise man want to lose this light in the darkness of intoxication? No, by

god!”247-5

257 in answer to questions, Shoghi effendi’s elucidations, written on his be-

258 half, provide further guidance on this subject. in these letters the habit of

drinking is described as a “great misery” and a “great evil.”

259 it was the policy of Shoghi effendi, upheld by the house of justice, that,

260 in the early stages of the teaching work in countries whose people have for

261 centuries been accustomed to the use of alcohol, the institutions should be

262 patient and lenient, educate the friends, and allow time for them to extricate
themselves from this pernicious habit before applying sanctions. This educa-tion has been an
ongoing process. regretfully, however, it has been seen that

263 in some cases, even among certain prominent believers, the friends have not freed
themselves from this practice. Some may have wrongly thought that light alcoholic drinks, if
taken irregularly, were permitted, without real-

264 izing the detrimental effect that their example was having on others. it is

265 always most unfortunate when bahá'ís of long standing, and even members
266 of institutions at the national level, partake of alcoholic beverages, thus
267 damaging themselves, harming the good name of the faith in the eyes of
268 non-b ahá'ís, and setting a bad example for the rank and file of the believers.

ment of the cause of god in those communities where there remains any

269 doubt among the friends as to the importance of obedience to this law,
270 that the National Spiritual Assemblies ensure that all believers are clearly
271 informed of it. of course, the Assemblies should not pry into the lives of
272 individual believers; but in the case of any bahá'í who blatantly violates the
273 law, he should be counseled, assisted to overcome the habit, warned repeat-
274 247-3. Adj, ¶49.

275 247-4. lg, no. 1171.247-5. cc 2:1790.247 .4

247 .5

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247 .7

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249 567edly of the consequences of continued disobedience, and ultimately, if he
250 does not respond positively, be deprived of his administrative rights.

251 furthermore, in order to protect the interests of the faith, the universal
252 house of justice has decided that, henceforth, any believer who occupies a
253 bahá'í administrative or teaching position on the national level and is seen to
254 be consuming alcoholic beverages, should not only be counseled but should
255 be removed from office during the process of the correction of his failing. if
256 he does not give up drinking, he should lose his administrative rights; if he

257 changes his ways, and the National Assembly is satisfied that he is obeying the law,
he would regain his full rights. The positions the house of justice

258 has in mind are those occupied by members of the National Spiritual As-sembly or
any committee under its aegis, whether national or regional, by bahá'ís who serve at the
national office or in the training institutes at any

259 level, and by traveling teachers and pioneers serving under the direction of the
National Assembly or its subsidiary agencies.

260 it is the hope of the house of justice that such a step will give a signal

261 to the entire community that, whatever the inherited cultural practices or
 262 tribal customs may be, every effort should be made by each conscientious
 263 believer to obey the sacred law of god which forbids the drinking of alcohol.
 264 The friends must become aware that there are certain essentials of bahá'í
 265 conduct that they cannot continue to disregard with impunity. continued,
 266 blatant disobedience to this law will, in the case of any believer, lead to consideration
 of deprivation of his voting rights. The friends should also realize that refusing to comply
 with this requirement will not only harm the
 267 offender and injure his family but will certainly impede his spiritual devel-
 268 opment and lead to the cessation of the confirmations of bahá'u'lláh—con-
 269 firmations and blessings without which his life will eventually be brought down to
 misery.

270 love for god is best exemplified not through words, but through deeds.

“let deeds,” bahá'u'lláh says, “not words, be your adorning.”

271 247-6 by obeying
 272 his laws we demonstrate our love for him. he has also written: “m y love
 273 is my stronghold; he that entereth therein is safe and secure, and he that

turneth away shall surely stray and perish.”247-7

274 247-6. hw , persian, no. 5.

275 247-7 . hw , Arabic, no. 9.247 .8

247 .9

247 .10

248 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

249 568The guideline that Shoghi effendi gave at the outset of the Ten year
 250 crusade, setting forth the manner in which the bahá'í law on the need to
 251 abstain from alcoholic drinks should be explained while teaching the faith
 252 to the people of Africa, is as applicable today as it was in 1953 when the
 253 guardian's secretary gave the following advice on his behalf:

The question of impressing upon the Africans who are seeking enroll-

254 ment the necessity of not drinking is a delicate one. when enrolling new
 255 believers, we must be wise and gentle, and not place so many obstacles in their way
 that they feel it impossible to accept the faith. on the other

hand, once accorded membership in the community of the followers of

256 bahá'u'lláh, it must be brought home to them that they are expected to live

257 up to his Teachings, and to show forth the signs of a noble character in

258 conformity with his laws. This can often be done gradually, after the new

259 believer is enrolled.

260 every effort should thus be made by the institutions of the faith, as well

261 as by those who are directly engaged in the expansion and consolidation work, to
make conscious and determined efforts to assist the new believers

262 to realize the grave consequences of disobedience to god's laws, and to ap-

263 preciate the bounties that flow from growing spiritually under the shadow

264 of his holy cause.

265 the Sacred Threshold, that you may be guided in the stewardship of your community
as you strive to promote the vital interests of the faith.

266 with loving bahá'í greetings,

for Department of the Secretariat

267 248

Message to the Iranian Believers—

March/April 1997

268 Bahá 154 B.E.

269 To the lovers of the most great beauty, beloved and faithful friends,

270 The tremendous forces latent in the inmost reality of this precious faith

271 exert daily a fresh influence in the contingent world and shine forth with greater
intensity. Through the outpourings of bahá'u'lláh's bounties, and as 247 .11

247 .12

247 .13

247 .14

248 1

249 1996–2000 • The Four Year Plan

250 a result of dictates of the time as well as the mighty efforts exerted by the

251 followers of his beauty, the faith's life-giving Teachings are taking root in

252 the world of being, increasing its prestige and manifesting evermore its power to
solve the problems confronting humanity. The blessed divine Tree, we

253 must know, is firmly rooted in the ground, while its branches and offshoots are
growing heavenward. All this has been possible through the interaction
254 and cooperation of two mighty, dominant forces which, in compliance with
255 god's will, are at work simultaneously, enabling the blessed Tree to grow, put
256 forth its leaves and blossoms and, at the appointed time, offer to humankind its
choicest fruits. one of the generating powers of this spiritual springtime is
257 tempestuous and soul-stirring in nature; causing lightning and thunder, high winds,
torrential rain, and roaring floods. These in turn cause the orchards and fields to become
verdant and fruitful. The other is the inherent capac-
258 ity for growth latent in the blessed seed. it is this capacity that causes the
259 seed to grow as an essential necessity. The rays of the Sun of Truth and the
260 sprinklings of the cloud of bounty help it to grow and become a mighty and
fruit-bearing tree, providing a celestial retreat for the guided birds of the field.
261 The overall divine design which leads humanity to spiritual maturity is not
262 within our control; it is well guarded in god's hidden treasure house and its
263 realization is dependent on his will. 'Abdu'l-bahá says:

**in this wondrous Age, at this time when the Ancient beauty, the most
great Name, bearing unnumbered gifts, hath risen above the horizon
of the world, the word of god hath infused such awesome power into
the inmost essence of humankind that he hath stripped men's human**

264 qualities of all effect, and hath, with his all-conquering might, uni-
265 fied the peoples in a vast sea of oneness.

266 248-1

267 The duty of the people of bahá is to tread the path of servitude to the
268 divine Threshold, it is to spread god's Teachings and establish a spiritual
269 civilization. praised be god, the loved ones of god throughout the world
270 have, for such a long time, hearkened to the directives of the center of
271 the cause and, guided by the divinely ordained institutions of the faith
272 and according to specific plans, have advanced step by step to hoist the
273 248-1. Sw Ab, no. 7.2.248.1a

248 2

249 m e S a g e f r o m T h e u n i v e r s a l h o u s e o f j u s t i c e

250 570 banner of the most great Name in every corner of the globe. The last in
 251 the chain of systematic successes achieved was the Three year plan which
 252 ended last rixvân and produced heartwarming results. during those three
 253 years twelve new National Spiritual Assemblies were established, raising the
 254 number of National Assemblies to 174. Also, during that short span of time a
 considerable number of bahá'ís, like unto a gentle breeze, passed
 255 through other countries and lands, engaging in the spreading of divine fragrances,
 enlisting a number of new believers under the banner of the cause of bahá'u'lláh, and
 deepening their understanding of the tenets of
 256 the faith. These achievements paved the way for the formulation of the
 257 present four year plan which outlines the duties of the people of bahá to
 258 the end of the twentieth century and mobilizes them to forge ahead and accelerate the
 process of fulfillment of divine prophecies. These teaching
 259 plans, which have successively set the worldwide bahá'í community on the
 260 move and broadened the boundaries of the faith, are the product of the
 261 creative power of 'Abdu'l-b ahá's Tablets of the divine plan. over eighty
 262 years ago he summoned the followers of the Abhá beauty to the spiritual
 263 conquest of the planet and gave them this responsibility. Thus, the teaching
 264 plans will continue until the golden Age.
 265 The collective duty and responsibility of the believers during the next
 266 four years has been spelled out in our last rixvân message and the new
 267 plan's prominent features explained. The believers have subsequently been
 268 actively engaged in carrying out its provisions. The focus of the present message is
 the iranian bahá'ís, who, when the dawn of guidance broke,
 269 turned their faces to the Sun of Truth and like unto birds of the dawn sang the songs
 of welcome and allegiance to him, taking the joyful tidings of
 270 reunion to the people of every land in accordance with this celestial melody:

Announce unto yourselves the joyful tidings: "he who is the best-

beloved is come! he hath crowned himself with the glory of god's

revelation, and hath unlocked to the face of men the doors of his

271 ancient paradise." let all eyes rejoice, and let every ear be gladdened,

272 for now is the time to gaze on his beauty, now is the fit time to hear-

**ken to his voice. proclaim unto every longing lover: "b ehold, your
well-beloved hath come among men!"**

273 248-2

274 248-2. gwb, no. 151.1.248.3

248 3a

249 1996–2000 • T h e f o u r Y e a r P l a n

250 571The iranian believers were not content just with spreading the divine

251 call; they rallied around the promised one and arose to render him as-

252 sistance in whatever way they could. life in hand and rank upon rank they

253 hastened to the field of martyrdom. The memory of their sacrifices has been

254 perpetuated by the Supreme pen. The account of their heroism is too vivid

255 in the minds of those of us who are the physical and spiritual offspring of

256 such valiant and intoxicated lovers of the blessed beauty to need repetition

257 here. Suffice it to say that we need be on our guard to preserve with our life

258 the inestimable bounty bestowed upon us, lest ingratitude snatch the honor from our
hands.

The historical background which has conferred upon the friends from

259 bahá'u'lláh's land the privilege of being the first to believe in him and made

them distinct in many respects has focused upon them the attention of

260 bahá'ís all over the world. furthermore, in recent times when the gallant

261 believers in the cradle of the faith were again persecuted by the people of

malice, they defended, protected and proclaimed the cause of god with

262 the shield of detachment, reliance on god, heroism and certitude. This

263 redoubled the degree of the worldwide bahá'í community's expectation of

264 the iranian bahá'ís who are scattered throughout the free world. They must,

265 therefore, emulate the example of those lions of the field of steadfastness

266 and learn from them the lesson of servitude. consider the time when the

267 tempest of ordeals started to blow in iran again, how the spark of belief in

268 the hearts of the members of the community, dormant in some cases under the ashes
of worldly attachments, suddenly turned into a brilliant flame and

wiped out the dust of complacency and heedlessness. The warning sound

269 of the thunderbolt of events awakened them. They became mindful and, in the joyful
gathering place of nearness to god, drank the brimful chalice of

270 calamity. oblivious of self, they laid down their heads at the feet of the best

271 beloved. They faced depredation and dismissal from jobs with aloofness

and detachment from worldly goods. when the relentless enemy leveled

272 false, trumped-up charges against them to justify their evil doings, with a godly
demeanor and heavenly behavior the friends frustrated the adversar-

273 ies' designs and demonstrated the absurdity of their accusations, thereby

274 proving their innocence in the eyes of broad-minded iranians. The people

275 of malice deprived the bahá'í youth in iran of higher education. The youth,

276 however, did not sit idle. They busied themselves with the acquisition of hu-man
perfections. They endured every discomfort and persevered until in the realm of knowledge
they excelled their peers. The attainment of this high 248.4

248 5

249 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

250 572station and honor became possible when the friends in iran, old and young,

251 women and men, even very young children, realized that the remedy of all

252 their ills was the remembrance of god. They started to study the writings

253 regularly and systematically. it was through their study that the outpourings

254 of the holy Spirit, enshrined in every word of the Sacred writings, came to

255 their assistance and made of that community a new creation in whose eye the world
and whatever it contains is worth nothing when compared with

256 servitude to the divine Threshold, attainment of bahá'u'lláh's good pleasure

257 and eternal life in every one of god's worlds. Therefore, they patterned their

258 lives on the life-giving Teachings contained in the Sacred writings. conse-

259 quently, they became the glory of this world and of the next, succeeding in
promulgating the cause of god in the far corners of the world and among

260 the highest institutions of humankind.

The beloved friends from iran who are scattered throughout the free

261 world must never forget the grave responsibility they bear. for, the expect-

262 ant eye of everyone is turned towards them, waiting to behold in the mir-ror of their
deeds the splendors of god's Teachings. consider the beloved

263 guardian's appeal to those dear friends:

264 . . . the beloved friends and members of the Assemblies should, in the manifold
circumstances of their lives and in all their multifarious
265 dealings and pursuits, by their deeds, their bearing and demeanor,
266 seek to demonstrate to their fellow-countrymen the excellence of this sacred cause, to
vindicate its truth, and give living testimony to
267 its potency and the sublimity of its spirit. it is thus that the friends
268 should proceed, not confining themselves to the delivery of the mes-sage, to
explanations, expositions and elucidations. ‘Abdu’l-b ahá, the
269 chief interpreter of the faith of bahá’u’lláh, has written: “ wherefore
270 it is incumbent upon all bahá’ís to ponder this very delicate and vital
271 matter in their hearts, that, unlike other religions, they may not con-tent themselves
with the noise, the clamor, the hollowness of religious doctrine. Nay, rather, they should
exemplify in every aspect of their

lives those attributes and virtues that are born of god and should

arise to distinguish themselves by their goodly behavior. They should

justify their claim to be bahá’ís by deeds and not by name. he is a

true bahá’í who strives by day and by night to progress and advance

272 along the path of human endeavor, whose most cherished desire is so to live and act
as to enrich and illuminate the world, whose source of 248.6

248 6a

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250 57inspiration is the essence of divine virtue, whose aim in life is so to

conduct himself as to be the cause of infinite progress. only when he

251 attains unto such perfect gifts can it be said of him that he is a true bahá’í. for in this
holy dispensation, the crowning glory of bygone

252 ages and cycles, true faith is no mere acknowledgement of the unity of god, but rather
the living of a life that will manifest all the perfections

253 and virtues implied in such belief.” See how firm and strongly-worded is this
statement of ‘Abdu’l-b ahá’s, and how demanding its require-

254 ments! Notwithstanding, it is only when the bahá’ís are able fully and

befittingly to distinguish their characters by the adornment of these

255 divine virtues that they will appear before the eyes of the world in a

worthy and appropriate manner and that the name of bahá’u’lláh will

set the universe ablaze. The chosen ones of god in iran should not

256 look at the depraved condition of the society in which they live, nor at the evidences
of moral degradation and frivolous conduct which the people around them display. They
should not content themselves merely with relative distinction and excellence. rather they
should fix

257 their gaze upon nobler heights by setting the counsels and exhorta-tions of the pen of
glory as their supreme goal. Then it will be readily

258 realized how numerous are the stages that still remain to be traversed and how far off
the desired goal lies—a goal which is none other than

exemplifying heavenly morals and virtues. Therefore, as the treaders

259 of the path of salvation, we should strive with all our might and in every moment of
our life to vindicate by deeds and words the reviv-

260 ing power enshrined in bahá'u'lláh's Teachings. in our association and

261 conversation with others, in our transactions, performance of duties,

262 our aims, and in major and minor undertakings we should so appear as to proclaim
and prove to all that other than the unifying power of

bahá'u'lláh's Spirit nothing can transform the hearts of people and

make of them a new race of men. This is the only means for the salva-

263 tion and victory of the cause of g od.

264 The lovers of the blessed beauty in iran, assisted by the promise which

265 says, "This is the only means for the salvation and victory of the cause of

266 god," saw clearly how astonished the enemies were when they witnessed the

267 fortitude of the friends under trials and their deeds which complied com-pletely with
divine exhortations. it was such behavior that turned strangers

268 into friends and supporters of the wronged ones. it is certain that tests are

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250 57not confined to the iranian friends; the ordeals which confront the believ-

251 ers in the free world, although different in nature, will be as severe and

252 deceitful. if they do not face such tests with the aid of a prayerful attitude

253 and constant engagement in service, they are likely to be submerged in the

254 ocean of bewilderment, confusion and remorse, wasting away the short days of their
lives and leaving this world with empty hands. of particular

255 importance is the training of the youth to enable them to stand firm against the perils
of the society in which they live. They should be encouraged to participate in bahá'í
activities, while pursuing their education in fields

256 which benefit humanity.

257 bahá'u'lláh says:

**whosoever attaineth divine love at the earliest stages of youth, that
one is accounted among the dwellers of the highest paradise. Strive
that from thee mayest appear that which will cause the exaltation of
the f aith.**

259 Also:

**o thou who art young in age! may the confirmations of the merci-
ful enable thee to attain unto his bountiful bestowals. Since thou
wert adorned with the recognition of the daystar of revelation when
thou wert in the prime of youth, beseech thou god to enable thee
to achieve that which will be immortalized in the book of existence.
mortality overtaketh everything except what is uttered and carried out
for god's sake; such [words and deeds] are deathless. Strive that thou
mayest drink of the wine of immortality and attain unto the kawthar
of steadfastness."**

we ardently hope that bahá'í youth who have their roots in the cradle

263 of the faith will, in all affairs, stand out among their peers. The youth
264 who received bahá'í education have, undoubtedly, reached the stage when
265 they can fend for themselves and face the tempestuous tests of the present
266 day world with valor, confidence and self-assurance. The bahá'í youth who
267 have distinguished themselves and stood out in the non-b ahá'í world are a
268 testimony to the truth of this statement.

269 The persecuted bahá'ís of iran are deprived of the bounty of teaching the
270 cause of god. The effect of this deprivation, which they regret immensely, 248.7a

248 7b

248 8

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249

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250

575 is mitigated when they hear that friends in other countries are carrying out

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teaching work on their behalf, or have arisen to execute a project in their

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name or in the name of the precious martyrs of that land. Such glad tidings

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prompt the iranian friends to offer loving prayers for the success of the

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efforts of their faithful comrades in other parts of the world. we now join

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our eager voice to that of these iranian believers and appeal to the friends

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from bahá'u'lláh's birthplace in every part of the globe to arise in accordance

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with the requirement of faithfulness and make mighty and effective efforts to teach the cause of god on behalf of their long-suffering brothers and

258

sisters. for, teaching the faith is a spiritual obligation from which no one is

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exempt; it is the magnet that attracts divine confirmations, it is the cause of the revival of hearts and souls. The Supreme pen says:

center your energies in the propagation of the faith of god. whoso is

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worthy of so high a calling, let him arise and promote it. whoso is un-

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able, it is his duty to appoint him who will, in his stead, proclaim this revelation, whose power hath caused the foundations of the mighti-

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est structures to quake, every mountain to be crushed into dust, and every soul to be dumbfounded.

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248-3

264

he also says:

in one of the Tablets this exalted word hath been revealed from the

Supreme pen: " whoso is unable to teach should appoint a deputy."

praised be god, this munificent banquet is now spread for the enjoy-

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ment of all. The four year plan provides guidance to each and every one

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involved with the achievement of the teaching goals. in some cases, when

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people are unable to directly teach the cause, they have been exhorted to

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deputize someone to carry out this duty on their behalf. Should they be unable to deputize one person, they can, in accordance with their financial

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ability, make contributions earmarked for deputization through local, na-

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tional, continental and international funds of the faith. in brief, all means

271 have been provided for everyone to participate in the teaching work which,
according to ‘Abdu’l-b ahá, is the foremost duty, leaving no room for any

272 248-3. gwb, no. 96.3.248.9a

248 9b

248 10

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250 576excuse. moreover, the people of the world who are weary and helpless in the

251 face of present-day ordeals are more than ever ready to embrace the cause of

252 god. failure to take advantage of this opportunity would indeed be a grave

253 loss, for it would deprive the aching body of humanity of a remedy placed

254 freely in the hands of the people of bahá. This is the day on which, accord-

255 ing to ‘Abdu’l-b ahá, “The cry of ‘where are bahá’í teachers’ is raised from

256 every corner of the world. . . .” blessed are the ones who have hearkened

257 and responded with heart and soul. This appeal is particularly significant these days
because, according to the four year plan, in the concluding years

258 of this century the number of teachers should so increase as to hasten the

259 entry of troops under the shadow of god’s cause. The dearly loved iranian

260 believers, wherever they reside, must not deprive themselves of the bounty

261 of participation in bahá’í activities. They should rather arise unitedly with

262 the native friends and join forces with them to offer befitting service under the
direction of bahá’í institutions. Nay, they should even take the lead and

263 become renowned in servitude to the d ivine Threshold.

Another matter of great import which the iranian believers cannot af-

264 ford to neglect is the instruction of children in spiritual attributes, human perfections
and heavenly character. in this, too, they can learn from the ex-

265 ample of the sacrificial friends of iran who train their children from infancy

266 under their loving care, adorn them with the ornaments of a praiseworthy

267 character, and help them to advance in the acquisition of knowledge and

268 understanding of spiritual truths, thus exemplifying this exhortation from ‘Abdu’l-b
ahá:

269 . . . exert every effort to educate the children, so that from infancy they will be trained
in bahá’í conduct and the ways of god, and will, even

270 as young plants, thrive and flourish in the soft-flowing waters that are

271 the counsels and admonitions of the blessed beauty.

272 248-4

273 Also:

it is incumbent upon bahá'í children to surpass other children in the

274 acquisition of sciences and arts, for they have been cradled in the grace of god.

275 248-4. Sw Ab, no. 97 .2.248.11

248 11a

248 11b

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250 577whatever other children learn in a year, let bahá'í children learn in a

month.248-5

251 And again:

while the children are yet in their infancy feed them from the breast

252 of heavenly grace, foster them in the cradle of all excellence, rear them in the embrace
of bounty. give them the advantage of every useful

kind of knowledge. let them share in every new and rare and won-

drous craft and art. bring them up to work and strive, and accustom

253 them to hardship.

254 248-6

255 consider carefully the following statement revealed by the pen of the An-

256 cient beauty:

257 The parents must exert every effort to rear their offspring to be religious, for should
the children not attain this greatest of adornments, they will not obey their parents, which in
a certain sense means that

they will not obey god. indeed, such children will show no consider-

258 ation to anyone, and will do exactly as they please.

259 248-7

260 Nowadays in many countries people are rebellious and careless, morally

261 corrupt and afflicted with various problems. At a time like this, obedience to

262 the above ordinances is more vital than ever before. The friends in iran have

263 successfully put these ordinances to work and learned through experience

264 that one of the immediate results of this endeavor is to empower their pre-
265 cious children at an early age to confront difficulties in school, on the street and in the
market-place and to show forth heroism, thereby preserving their integrity and safeguarding
the reputation of the faith. The friends in other
266 parts of the world should do likewise. for, should the children be deprived
267 of a spiritual foundation, their protection from the onslaught of destructive
temptations will be compromised.

one of the laudable services which the iranian bahá'ís everywhere can

268 pledge to perform is initiating work on establishing character training classes
269 248-5. Sw Ab, no. 119.1-2.
270 248-6. Sw Ab, no. 102.3.
271 248-7 . lg, no. 763. 248.11c
248 11d
248 12
248 13
249 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e
250 578for children and rendering assistance in maintaining them. Those friends
251 who were the pupils of these classes and have enjoyed the sweetness of
252 the fruits of such education should actively participate in this great service,
253 which is the cause of strengthening every bahá'í community, and provide
254 for children's b ahá'í education everywhere.

furthermore, the bahá'í parents from iranian background should en-

255 deavor to teach their children the persian language, for persian is one of the
256 two languages of revelation in this glorious dispensation. bahá'u'lláh says:
257 "in this day when the Sun of knowledge hath appeared and is resplendent
258 from the firmament of iran, it is fitting to praise this language as much
259 as one can." he also says: "The desire of the world speaks in the persian
260 language. it would be praiseworthy to him, if his loved ones also converse

and write in this language."

261 it would be a great service if, in every city and hamlet where a number
262 of iranian bahá'ís reside, some persian friends would exert special effort to

263 teach this language to the children and youth, study together the writings in
264 persian, and drink their fill from the billowing source of the creative word
265 and Sacred writings. we praise god for having enabled some bahá'í institu-
266 tions abroad to devise ways and develop programs useful for teaching the persian
language to those iranians who live away from their homeland. Such
267 programs can be put to good use for the achievement of this blessed service.

The valued friends of iran have always been and continue to be at the

268 forefront in rendering worthy services to the cause of god. we need not
269 review the record of sacrifices made in the arena of faithfulness by the he-
270 roes of the Apostolic Age. A careful look at the early stages of the formative
271 Age will enlighten us about the historic and crucial services of the iranian
272 believers in glorifying the cause of god and its establishment throughout
273 the world, and will evoke our admiration and praise. in the Ten year plan,
274 which the beloved guardian called the world Spiritual crusade, a consid-
275 erable number of iranian bahá'ís succeeded in opening up countries and
276 territories to the light of the faith. The names of these knights have been
277 recorded in the roll of honor. Also, numerous are those who have contrib-
278 uted generously to the establishment of essential and significant institu-
279 tions. recently, when monetary donations for the construction of buildings
280 on the Arc became a necessity, the iranian friends living abroad considered
281 it unbecoming to lag behind others. As before, they stepped forth with high endeavor
and participated as much as possible in providing the financial needs of those mighty
institutions.248.14

248 15

248 16

249 1996–2000 • T h e f o u r Y e a r P l a n

250 579o friends of god, it is certain that the cloud of divine bounty and bestow-
251 al rains equally upon all humanity. however, we each partake of it according
252 to our capacity. Although potentialities differ in accordance with degrees,
253 not a single soul is completely bereft of capacity. indeed, people's progress
254 in this world is dependent on that preordained measure and the manner in which
they fulfill their god-given potentiality. Accordingly, our responsibil-

255 ity is commensurate with our capacity, as it is said: "g od will not burden
 256 any soul beyond its capacity." it is our ardent hope that the lifelong lovers
 257 of the divine beauty will, in the privacy of their conscience and in the pres-
 258 ence of god, thoroughly assess their ability, judge their situation, and decide
 259 what kind and extent of service they can render in the path of the love of bahá'u'lláh,
 then offer it in fulfillment of a vow of faithfulness, that they may
 260 attain the bounty of reunion in the everlasting world and reap the harvest of
 261 their existence. otherwise, if they think only of their own comfort in this
 262 mortal life and be heedless of the purpose of creation, undoubtedly they will
 263 bring loss and regret upon themselves. 'Abdu'l-b ahá says:

of what benefit to humanity is the body's comfort which consists

264 of the night's rest, the day's talk, the gathering of provisions in the morning,
 enjoyment of the fireplace in the evening, and the pleasure of a highly comfortable and
 extravagant bed made of finest silk and

brocade! A considerable time is wasted in idle talk. once it comes to

265 an end, it is loss upon loss and manifest perdition.
 266 how penetrating is bahá'u'lláh's utterance which exhorts his faithful ser-
 267 vants thus:

Night hath succeeded day, and day hath succeeded night, and the

268 hours and moments of your lives have come and gone, and yet none of you hath, for
 one instant, consented to detach himself from that

which perisheth. bestir yourselves, that the brief moments that are

still yours may not be dissipated and lost. even as the swiftness of

lightning your days shall pass, and your bodies shall be laid to rest

beneath a canopy of dust. what can ye then achieve? how can ye

269 atone for your past failure?

270 248-8

271 248-8. gwb, no. 151.4.248.17

248 17a

248 17b

249 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

250 580o beloved and faithful friends from the land of bahá'u'lláh's birth! our
251 longing, nay our hope and expectation of those valued friends is this: that
in obedience to divine commandments and exhortations, you become like
252 unto morning stars, shining from the horizon of guidance and leading the
253 way, thereby attaining unto that which the peerless beloved has desired and
254 ordained for you.
255 249

Riḍván Message 1997

Riḍván 154

To the b ahá'ís of the w orld

256 dearly loved f riends,
257 we acclaim with grateful hearts the eager response on all continents to
258 the f our y ear p lan launched last riḍván.

consultations of the continental counselors and National Spiritual

259 Assemblies started an extensive planning process, also involving Auxiliary board
members and local Spiritual Assemblies. Through such a process the
260 national and regional character of the derivative plans took shape. but this
261 world-encompassing exercise did more than yield distinctive schemes for the
different countries; it also boosted the collaborative relationship of the two arms of the
Administrative order, a most welcome portent of the victories
262 yet to come.

A sign of the immediate impact of the plan was the speed with which

263 steps were taken to establish nearly two hundred training institutes during
264 the last twelve months. many of these have gone far beyond the point of
265 designing their organization; they are actually in operation and have offered
266 their first courses. moreover, in the movement of homefront and interna-
267 tional pioneers and traveling teachers; in the increased attention given by
268 individuals to deputizing teachers; in the preparations made to ensure the
269 formation of local Spiritual Assemblies only on the first day of riḍván; in
270 the increasing endeavors to hold regular devotional meetings; in the widen-ing
efforts to make use of the arts in the teaching work and community

271 activities—in all these respects could be discerned the friends' keen aware-
272 ness of the importance of concentrating on the requirements of the major 248.18

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250 1996–2000 • T h e f o u r Y e a r P l a n

251 581aim of the plan, which is to effect a significant advance in the process of
252 entry by troops.

253 Nor can we neglect to recognize other developments during the past year
254 which confirmed the high merit of the manifold efforts being exerted by our
255 world community and the results being achieved. Among these, to mention a few,
were: the acquisition of the apartment at 4 Avenue de camoëns in

256 paris where the beloved master, 'Abdu'l-b ahá, resided during his historic
257 visit to the city; the special session on 14 August of the federal chamber
258 of deputies in brazil to mark the 75th anniversary of the introduction of
259 the bahá'í faith into that country—a unique, official occasion at which

Amatu'l-b ahá rú'íyyih khánum was present as the honored guest; the

260 launching last july of the bahá'í international community's site on the
261 world wide web, entitled "The bahá'í world," which to date has received
262 from more than 90 countries and territories over 50,000 visits, averaging some 200 per
day.

hardly outpaced by such accomplishments, the construction projects

on mount carmel maintained a dazzling momentum highlighted by the

completion of the marble colonnade of the center for the Study of the

263 Texts, by the rise of the international Teaching center building towards its
264 seventh level, and by the ongoing emergence of the far-stretching features of the
Terraces of the Shrine of the báb. in this connection must be men-

265 tioned the partial lowering of the section of the public road over which the line of
terraces will pass, and the acquisition and subsequent demolition of the building at the foot
of the mountain which stood as the last obstruction

266 that had to be overcome to make possible the completion of the lower ter-
267 races through which the glorious pathway rises up towards the sacred edifice

268 and beyond it to the crest of the hill of God.

269 Also of acute relevance to the progress thus described was the maintenance of a level of contributions to the Arc projects fund which fulfilled

270 the goal for the last year. clearly, the financial demands in this regard are

271 being met with incessant heroism by rich and poor alike, and must be sustained over the remaining years. At the same time, however, a parallel effort,

272 equally strenuous and sustained, should be simultaneously exerted by the

273 Assemblies and friends throughout the world to fill the critical needs of the Bahá'í International Fund.

274 Such an auspicious beginning to the four year plan as has been experienced cannot but inspire confidence in the hearts of the members of our

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250 message from The Universal House of Justice

251 582 worldwide community that they are fully equipped to execute its requirements as outlined in the messages that launched it, and as elaborated in the

252 plans adopted by their respective Assemblies. A further and especially appreciated encouragement as we enter this second year is that circumstances have

253 made it feasible for the reestablishment this Ríxvân of the National

254 Spiritual Assembly of Rwanda. This victory over crisis will bring to 175 the

255 number of National Spiritual Assemblies that will be eligible to participate in the

256 eighth international Bahá'í convention to be held next Ríxvân at

the Bahá'í world center. how dearly we hope that by then, at the very

257 midpoint of the plan, the Bahá'í world will have made a major leap forward

258 in the multiplication of its human resources, the maturation of its Spiritual Assemblies, and the evolution of its local communities!

The opportunity offered by the brief span of time before the century

259 ends is precious beyond all telling. only a united and sustained effort by

260 the friends everywhere to advance the process of entry by troops can be-fit such a historic moment. responsibilities urgent and inescapable press

261 upon every institution, every member of a community striving towards its

262 God-promised destiny. As there is only a short period in which to achieve

263 a great deal, no time must be spared, no opportunity lost. rest assured,
264 dear friends, that the hosts of the Abhá kingdom stand ready to rush to
265 the support of anyone who will arise to offer his or her acts of service to the
unfolding, spiritual drama of these momentous days.

266 250

Formation of Regional Bahá'í Councils

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]